

Session 18: The False Light and the Buried Memory

Rebuilt September 30, 2026 from Session 17 and the current story arc. Supersedes the September 29 Session 18 outline. Scott authorized this rebuild and its repository save. This guide is preparation; outcomes remain unplayed. New bounded DM background is recorded separately in the canon files. The Concordance/Acererak spine remains unconfirmed.

The session's story

The party already stole the information needed to stop Frulam's operation. Now use it. After defending Greenest, discover why the mill's old draconic structure matters to people above it. The hidden object preserves a local stable reading; the relief stone is adding strain to damaged supports. Protect patients while gaining evidence, then carry the plate and witness north to question an independent dragon. This continues Runara's lead while revealing the Cult of the Dragon as a recognizable opponent.

Three promises: their defense choices matter; Floyd GoldSeeker's practical leadership opens the mystery; the dragon offers partial information at a negotiable price. Avoid another session spent mainly collecting papers.

Three-hour running order

Beat	Minutes	Choice / payoff
Restart	10	Confirm orders, signal intent, resources and plate holder; drums begin.
Operation	50	Cut rapidly between four fronts; let good disruption stop the raid.
Cult evidence / regroup	15	One witness or dispatch identifies Frulam and faction.
Mill recovery	35	Safe shoring, portable witness, familiar draconic geometry.
Relief and cost	25	Arrange care and choose reversible receiver isolation or monitored continuation.
North / dragon	35	Earn route; choose how to approach and bargain for information.
Close	10	Record real results and next objective.

When behind, remove extra fights and travel checks. A protected overnight work montage can finish excavation; no automatic long rest. If dragon dialogue must wait, end northbound with two concrete questions and a reliable route. Do not rush a patient's care choice to hit a timetable.

Five-character spotlight card

Floyd GoldSeeker: decide how crews shore a loaded wall, teach a volunteer and invite help. Payoff is safer people and a useful reading, not a compelled revelation about Glittervein. Brother Kai: keep workers safe, decide how to treat a captive, listen to Merra without automatic conversion or condemnation. Pat-Benatar: choose an exact false signal, recognize old geometry and ask the dragon what predates her clan. Severed Whisper: control the road encounter, decide which map information to share and scout a safe northbound approach. Throk: define his west-path purpose, protect runners or intercept the ordinary messenger, account for his team's people. Give one short decision to each every operation beat; reunite them for discovery.

RAW and homebrew boundaries

Use the official Greenest/camp functions: defend townspeople and mill, recover prisoner intelligence, expose a cult operation and offer a camp/hatchery trail. The modified signal network and buried vault are custom. Do not claim to be executing the published encounters unchanged. No mandatory dragon breath attack, siege, champion duel or extra wave.

Frulam is an active antagonist through orders and surviving personnel. Lennithon is an independent actor with overlapping interests. Sister Merra's One God belief is a separate religious response to the local fault, not a Cult of the Dragon disguise. The mill predates the recent raid and Stormwreck signal. Repairs are a net good. No universal machine, future villain identity or compulsory collection of keys.

Opening dashboard

Front	Confirmed deployment	First meaningful question
Mill	Floyd GoldSeeker, Brother Kai, both work crews	Which seam is safe, who braces it, and who watches the entrance?
Ridge	Pat-Benatar, two guard teams	Capture, kill, drive off or isolate the two observers? What exact signal follows?
West path	Throk, third guard team	Observe, block, protect runners or patrol toward the mill?
North road	Severed Whisper alone	Tree concealment, visible bluff, or another opening posture?

Ask each player for one concrete opening order. Confirm the control plate's carrier; Severed Whisper last explicitly held it at camp. Confirm the two carts, runner route, rally point and retreat signal. Do not quietly transfer the plate to Throk because older Session 16 notes say he held it.

Resource check: five level-2 PCs; sheet values last refreshed September 1. A short rest was initiated in Session 17, but individual recovery is unverified. Healing Word on Doss was cast with uncertain attribution and amount. Two shields were acquired with recipients uncertain. Confirm current HP, slots, hit dice, features, ammunition, consumables and equipped shields with players. No automatic long rest or level-up. Resistance potion types and minor-healing-potion mechanics remain unconfirmed. Doss is in sanctuary care; Mara continued north. No 40 gp was paid.

Preserve the existing protected background: town guards outside the three reassigned teams still guard their posts; sanctuary care continues; the bridge was not burned. Council location labels remain unresolved. Do not settle those discrepancies through descriptive art.

Enemy order card: what actually releases Spade

Wheel has two straw-loaded wagons, six shields originally (two taken at camp), two drums, no ram, ladders or occupation supplies. They arrive visibly at dusk, make noise and await further orders before entering. Prepared head count: four hired raiders, two per wagon; not a new historical fact.

Lantern has two observers on the ridge. After drums begin, they watch defenders. One long shuttered flash only when defenders move north. Otherwise hold and send a runner. These are observers, not suicidal champions.

Spade has eight people with picks, pry bars, rope and timber braces. Foot-only east drainage route to mill work entrance, then shallow space beneath. Brace and breach masonry beside the sealed arch. Retrieve contents; keep mill and channels standing. Do not await the plate. Move only on one long shuttered flash; otherwise hold.

Enemies do not know secret friendly deployments unless they observe them or receive a report. Camp personnel heard that the party carried the plate; that does not locate it at dusk. A sent runner takes time. No telepathy, unseen reinforcements or automatic dragon retaliation.

Resolve four fronts without four separate full battles

Use three operation beats of roughly five to ten fictional minutes. At each beat, give every front a short scene and one consequential choice, then update only effects actually caused. When a local fight needs initiative, stop the operation clock for its few rounds; do not let ten fictional minutes pass while another player says one sentence. Across distant fronts use local initiative; characters cannot share spells, sight or turns across the town.

Write four states on paper: Ridge [enemy / contested / party]; Wheel [waiting / suspicious / withdrawing / advancing]; Spade [holding / scouting / moving / withdrawn]; Mill [unbraced / braced / clearance / access / recovery]. Add each runner's departure, destination and arrival. Prepared communication: a nearby post takes one beat; opposite fronts two beats. These are broad scene durations, not surveyed distances. Confirm against the established strategy map; never promise remote help in the same six-second round.

A credible task within a team's capacity succeeds without a roll. Roll only when opposition, risk or timing matters. Prepared command DCs: 10 straightforward under pressure, 12 disputed or watched, 14 difficult deception with contradictory evidence. Clear tools, terrain or preparation may grant advantage. State what failure costs before rolling. One failed command changes a position or costs time; it does not randomly kill a team.

Prepared guard-team abstraction for scenes without PCs: Fresh -> Pressed -> Withdrawn. Good cover and explicit limited orders hold a matching threat. A costly unsupported move makes the team Pressed; a second unsupported setback makes it Withdrawn with injuries needing care. Do not declare deaths from this track. If individual lives become central, resolve their actual situation. Both ridge teams cooperate against two observers; do not invent extra enemies to erase their numerical advantage. Volunteers brace, haul and dig; they do not become combat squads.

Beat 1: the drums and the shutter

Read A1 opening, then A2 drums. Ask Severed Whisper's posture before wagons arrive. He can watch from the tree, step onto the road, challenge the convoy, damage equipment, bluff about reinforcements or withdraw. Wheel wants visible noise, not instant occupation. Its wagon leader asks who stands for the town. A plausible threat can delay them; a lone adventurer does not automatically convince four people that an army exists.

At the ridge show two observers, shuttered lantern, hooded supply light, rock cover and escape path. Pat-Benatar has already brought enough support to isolate them. Let her distribute the two teams: one covers retreat while the other supports her approach, or both demand surrender. If concealed surprise is uncertain, compare the chosen approach to watchers who are currently looking toward town. If combat starts, use the existing S16 Hired Raider block for the observers. They surrender when cornered or one falls, unless the party chooses lethal force. Honor that

choice; do not narrate a kill before attacks resolve. Capturing the lamp intact is separate from incapacitating observers.

At the mill Floyd GoldSeeker can freely distinguish the old arch from the adjacent breach route. The lock is physically damaged; fitting the plate will not make the break disappear. Both crews can start quiet shoring. Brother Kai decides entrance watch, labor assistance or patient protection if someone is hurt. The old structure requires engineering, not a new four-statue puzzle.

At the west path give Throk a fair visible cue: a person on foot stops to look uphill toward the ridge, carrying no wagon load. Prepared this is the ordinary messenger allowed by the signal order. Throk can observe, question, stop, escort or let the messenger pass. The west path is not silently renamed the east drainage route. This front supports information and protects cross-town runners; it is not automatically Spade's route.

Beat 2: the party's signal changes the enemy's choices

Party action	Immediate consequence	Spade response
No flash; defenders stay in place	Written trigger absent	Holds; may send the ordered runner
Repeated/panic flashes	Not the authorized one-long-flash code	Holds, seeks clarification; does not automatically run into an ambush
One long flash after a convincing visible northward movement	Plausible valid trigger	Advances on foot toward mill; party can prepare interception
One long flash without observed movement	Contradictory evidence	Foreman sends a scout; eight do not charge blindly
Lamp broken or captured before signal	Observation link lost	Holds until information arrives; party gains time
Captured observer or convincing messenger supplies changed orders	Evaluate authority and what recipient can verify	Bargain, delay or redirection becomes possible

Pat-Benatar's false signal is the main bet. Ask what she wants enemies to believe. Repeated flashes can create doubt and buy excavation time; their success is disruption, not a magical panic code. If she wants to lure Spade in, she must meet or credibly explain the trigger. The party may choose darkness; preserve the late-session alternate proposal.

Wheel can notice a captured ridge, absent response or a provocative north-road challenge. Give it one observable reaction: drums hesitate, wagon leader looks uphill, or a runner departs. The convoy does not gain knowledge of the mill automatically. Let Severed Whisper decide whether to keep the feint occupied or pursue the messenger. A prepared escape down the townward road is available. Avoid focusing four simultaneous attackers on one wounded level-2 rogue for a mandatory combat.

Throk's team can secure a messenger and ask what was actually written. Useful plain answer: "We wait for one long light. If the town stays put, we wait." If a captured messenger knows the northern transfer marker, that is route evidence, not knowledge of the dragon's secrets. Preserve messenger identity as an unnamed role unless a player asks.

Beat 3: meet the actual attack, or protect the time you earned

If Spade holds, reward the signal plan. No obligatory mill combat. A brief attempted reconnaissance or negotiation is enough; the party has prevented the coordinated opening. If it advances, show water splashing and a covered tool knocking stone before contact. Eight pairs of boots is a count of the work party, not eight soldiers of equal threat.

Prepared Spade staging: two hired-raider escorts with six laborers. Laborers do not attack in formation; they drop tools, take cover, bargain or flee. A foreman can be one of the laborers, with no elite block. The escorts' goal is access and safe withdrawal. In tactical play place both escorts and the visible workers. Do not add a boss or hidden waves. Floyd GoldSeeker and Brother Kai can hold a braced choke, warn workers of collapse, negotiate with the foreman or call support. A sensible barrier changes the encounter before initiative.

If ridge and road clashes happen, use only brief local combats necessary for choices. Large forces retreat when their cover story or coordination fails. Capture is a real option. Wheel is not equipped to besiege Greenest. A battle can conclude with frightened hired people alive and the town secure.

If pressure overwhelms a front, runners and withdrawal are the consequence. Civilians can be injured and care can cost time, but no offscreen massacre is required. The intended successful arc remains available through regrouping, guarding the mill, bargaining or seizing the next opening. If players abandon all protection or lose the contents, preserve that result and revise the northbound objective; never retcon success to reach a prepared scene.

Quick local combat reference

Existing campaign S16 Hired Raider: AC 12, HP 9, speed 30 feet, club +3 to hit, 1d4+1 bludgeoning. Prepared two observers, two Spade escorts, four Wheel occupants reuse it when they actually fight. These are campaign blocks, not an assertion of an official monster stat block. All enemies have independent HP. No multiattack, spellcasting or ranged weapon invented. For a noncombatant use existing Commoner record; avoid attacking statistics unless play needs them. Use the table's chosen D&D rules for attacks, cover, concealment and nonlethal options.

Resolve allied guard help as position, containment and sensible pressure rather than adding a dozen NPC turns. If the team is physically in a fight and a player needs precise attacks, use its existing Roll20 guard record; do not use the Fresh/Pressed track as extra HP or an undisclosed combat buff.

Regroup: an enemy with a name

Give one earned clue, not another hunt. A captured observer, interrupted messenger, abandoned wagon docket or withdrawn Spade foreman's satchel holds H1. Do not conjure it in a pocket the party never searches. If all enemies escape, a dispatched courier drops the duplicate at the deserted ridge only if that is actually inspected; otherwise an existing town prisoner may know the employer when asked. Critical faction information is not locked behind one successful check.

H1 is an original adapted document: two short paragraphs naming Frulam Mondath and the Cult of the Dragon; recovery priorities and a separate northern transfer; one note that camp prisoners and guarded cave stock must be counted. It identifies neither a captured monk nor dragon eggs as confirmed discoveries. Read A7B. The paper turns F.M. into a supported identification. A common worker knows wage/order information; do not make them a cult theologian.

Nighthill asks who is hurt and who is held. Escobert returns ordinary watches; care continues. A live prisoner has information and a human decision attached. Pat-Benatar's proposed lethal attack remains her choice; do not impose a moral lecture. Brother Kai and Severed Whisper can speak about capture if they want, without replaying their old disagreement as scripted conflict.

Mill recovery: competent people, careful work

Show safe progress from crews' actual effort: brace, clear, supported access, supported recovery. Both crews may need until morning. DC12 for uncertain rushed execution; DC14 under active attack. State a time/bracing setback first. Competent tools and a good described plan need no roll. Volunteers are not expendable tokens. Floyd GoldSeeker shares authority with trained hands. Brother Kai watches the entrance or helps the lifting line.

The old arch stays shut. Clear adjacent masonry into a small maintenance recess. No enormous machinery appears. The removed plate does not repair the broken branch. New access is shored and kept out of public use. Read A8-A10 only at their gates. Optional CLICK requires an actionable slipping-brace/grit clue, only present PCs, three seconds, normal resolution, no instant death.

What is recovered: a pressure witness

Bounded DM background approved for this rebuild: a forearm-long, roughly ten-pound smoky crystal spindle in three old bronze ribs, three retaining clips and a single still amber line. It is a removable reference component retaining this vault's last stable local pressure reading. It is not a soul, egg, weapon or second plate. Release clips while supported, lift and pad. Correct practical action succeeds. No combat/healing powers. Removal leaves the architecture and damaged channels in place.

If the party actually brings the plate close, the witness shows a second offset line briefly. Explain the useful observation plainly: one stored reading and one present reading differ. They have found a way to compare, not a way to cure everything. If they do not test the plate, do not narrate that result. Pat-Benatar recognizes the geometric family; her scale need not produce a new involuntary vision. Floyd GoldSeeker can safely extract it; the whole party helps secure and understand it.

The homebrew turning point: help that loads the broken stone

While the group inspects the still-damaged mill channel, show one faint pulse from the sanctuary-facing branch and a fall of grit at its damaged support. This is a cue, not proof of all causes. A worker/runner reports that the timing resembles the sanctuary's relief stone; a visit to Merra/Eadyan allows a matched observation. Do not claim an offscreen new injury, cure or collapse.

At sanctuary Merra sincerely wants patients comfortable. Her stone provides real bounded relief. Eadyan wants a safe care plan, not a theological contest. Show relief and strain together using a short controlled pulse with consent and bracing. Read A15. Existing background defines its effects; new certainty must come through the test. If they question whether it caused the original fault, answer no: recent foundation work broke the branch; the receiver worsens stress at that break.

Decision: temporarily lift/isolate the receiver with replacement care, or continue monitored use with a propped channel and a scheduled review. No patient sacrifice, forced conversion or automatic death. Baseline healing/medicine does not vanish. Explain observed costs before asking. Merra may disagree but is persuadable; her sincerity is not a lie check. Reasonable plans succeed. If the party refuses to engage, the town can keep ordinary care/watch and the issue remains unresolved. Do not trap them in Greenest or prevent discovery/exit as punishment.

Isolation benefit if chosen and actually completed: the receiver's extra pulse stops and dust fall from that specific loading source ceases. The damaged branch stays broken; patients need the agreed replacement care. Monitored continuation benefit: safer support and explicit custodians reduce immediate risk, but strain remains. Record the chosen limited improvement. Both routes preserve a later return-to-Greenest problem. The portable witness is not required to remove the relief stone.

Why go north now?

Two intelligible questions: who understands the familiar draconic pattern, and why is a dragon interested in this local reading? Runara said follow dragons, not trust them. The cult wants possession; the party wants answers and decides custody. The local care/handoff makes leaving a responsible choice rather than abandoning Doss.

Use H2 transfer instruction from an earned messenger/docket, Mara at her next stop or recent tracks at the chalk fork. A split basalt shelf beyond the camp, foot track marked by three pale stones, is a rendezvous rather than a proven lair. Directions are approximate; no spindle GPS or instant travel. Confirm supplies, rest intention, item carriers, care custodian, team return orders and any prisoner arrangement. Avoid repeating the full camp investigation.

Lennithon: a limited independent bargaining encounter

The contact can initially remain shadowed. If players establish speech and ask a name, he may give Lennithon. This names the present speaker; it does not prove he was either prior distant omen or Session 17 flyover. No magical awareness of concealed inventory. No attack merely because adventurers came to talk. Do not put an adult dragon in obligatory level-2 combat.

His new bounded DM motive: he wants to compare the witness's stored local baseline and plate's interface with draconic disturbances he has sensed northward. He recognized outward Stormwreck activity, but neither created Greenest's original damage nor controls Frulam. He values information and independent access, not simply town loot.

Opening: with objects disclosed, "Frulam sends hands to take what she cannot read. You brought it yourselves. What do you want to know?" If objects concealed, ask what they came to discuss; no accusation based on invisible knowledge.

Negotiation menu: supervised inspection with party holding objects; copied measurements for copied information; information first, examination second; temporary custody with explicit return terms; refusal. He prefers retaining both but can accept a bounded exchange. No automatic surrender, forced oath, magical contract or allegiance. His threat is withheld information and departure, not a scripted breath weapon. Players can bargain, withdraw, distrust him or ask about the cult.

Answers to release through actual discussion:

- The mill and Observatory share old draconic design principles. Same family does not mean every site has the same job.
- This witness preserves a local stable reading. The plate addresses its local interface. Neither contains the cause of the wider wound.
- The rescued bronze dragon's release changed something dragons could feel. This did not create the mill's prior physical fault.
- Frulam's people want possession and northern transfer; the dragon has his own reasons. He can explain his own interest, not everyone's plans.
- He cannot identify the ultimate rift cause, Pat-Benatar's ancestry or Floyd GoldSeeker's divine source. He need not know the unidentified departure omen.

One supported connection, one limited answer, one new choice is enough. Avoid formal Concordance terms, Acererak, destiny speech or five new artifacts. If Pat-Benatar asks about her scale, "Older than the people who named it" is a partial inference from geometry, not a species/bloodline solution.

Distinct forward leads

Cult route: named Frulam + camp/prisoner/guarded-cave reference makes investigating captives or hatchery activity an optional next adventure. Leosin Erlanthar and dragon eggs are published candidates only until specifically introduced; no claim they were visible and missed in Session 17.

Homebrew route: return with the copied reading to investigate/repair the damaged branch and arrange community custody. The witness does not cure the architecture.

Dragon route: a bounded observation north can supply information without collecting another object or agreeing to serve him. Let the party choose which next objective is urgent.

Closing and durable record

Read A18 after earned conversation or A14 if ending on the journey. Ask each player what they need next. Record actual operation outcome, casualties, captives, volunteers' status, spent resources, plate/witness custody, receiver care decision, permanent improvement, remaining scar, dragon promises and chosen route. Session 18 remains unplayed until the table reports it.

Sources: current campaign 01/02/03/05/07/09/11 and Wizards official Hoard opening material. Full diagnosis: Session17_Postmortem.md.